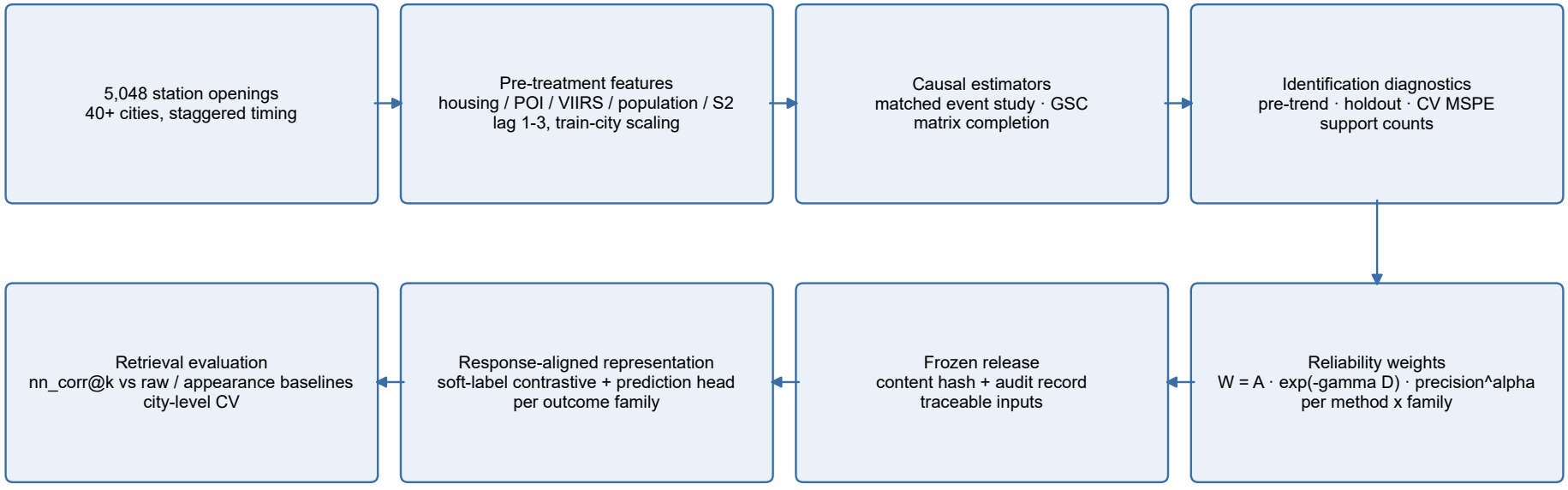Causal response pipeline and response-aligned representation learning